

Description of archaeological Sites for newly reported materials

Georgia

Dariali or Tamara's Fort (42.738050, 44.625633) is located in Georgia, in the Greater Caucasus mountainous range, at an altitude of 1,350 m asl. The site was investigated between 2013 and 2016 within the ERC project "Persia and its Neighbours", directed by E. Sauer, K. Pitshelauri and others. The site bears evidence of long-term occupation spanning more than a millennium. The earliest evidence of human occupation at Dariali dates back to between the 6th and 4th c. BCE. The fort was constructed in the late 4th c. CE (or early 5th c. CE at the latest). The fort was then occupied intensively until the late 10th/early 11th c. CE and reoccupied between the late 13th and early 15th c. CE. Except for the 20th c., when some military structures were positioned within the fort, there is no traceable post-medieval occupation (Sauer, 2020). A very large number of faunal remains were found and were studied by Mashkour and colleagues (Mashkour et al., 2020).

2.6.1.2 Iran

Ganj Dareh is an aceramic Neolithic mound located in the Kermanshah province of western Iran close between the city of Harsin and the Bisitoun massif. It was first excavated by Philip Smith in the late 1960s and 1970s and re-excavated by a joint Iranian-Danish mission in 2016 and 2017. The site comprises five major occupation levels dated to between c. 8200 - 7600 cal BCE. The most prominent is Level D, which preserved a dense cluster of rectangular structures. The faunal material from the most recent excavations are currently curated at the Department of Cross-Cultural and Regional Studies at the University of Copenhagen.

Kuran Buzan is located at Kuran Buzan Mountain, Hulailan Valley, Iran. The site was excavated by the Danish Archaeological Expedition in 1964. Faunal remains are from a habitation site on Kuran Buzan Mountain. The assemblage is of probable Bronze Age origin; the collection is at the Natural History Museum of Denmark (ZMK 115b/1965).

Tang-i-Hamamlan, is located at Kuran Buzan Mountain, Hulailan Valley, Iran. Excavated by the Danish Archaeological Expedition in 1964. Faunal remains are from a gorge or ravine on the mountain. Probable Bronze Age origin; the collection is at the Natural History Museum of Denmark (ZMK 115c/1965).

Tang-e-ktcheck is located at Kuran Buzan Mountain, Hulailan Valley, Iran. Excavated by the Danish Archaeological Expedition in 1964. Faunal remains from a cave habitation on Kuran Buzan Mountain. Probable Bronze Age origin; collection is at the Natural History Museum of Denmark (ZMK 115d/1965).

Tepe Jarali is located at Sar-i-Tarhan Valley, Iran. Excavated by the Danish Archaeological Expedition in 1964. Faunal remains from a house ruin on a small hill in the valley. These probably derived from the late Iron Age to Bronze Age; collection is at the Natural History Museum of Denmark (ZMK 115a/1965).

Uzbekistan

Bukhara is the principal urban centre of the oasis of the same name (in Uzbekistan) and has served as its political and economic capital since the Early Islamic period. The city consists of three main components: the Ark (citadel), the shahrestan (lower city), and the surrounding suburbs. Archaeological evidence indicates that the earliest occupation of the site dates to the 3rd century BCE. Initially organised around the citadel and an adjacent shahrestan located to the east, the settlement expanded considerably during the first centuries CE. Urban growth continued throughout Late Antiquity and the Early Medieval period, reaching a first apogee during the Samanid period (9th–10th centuries CE), when Bukhara became one of the major political and cultural centres of Central Asia. The city continued to expand during the Timurid period (14th–15th centuries CE) until the main urban transformation in the 16th and 17th centuries. Archaeological investigations conducted by the Franco-Uzbek Archaeological Mission in the Bukhara Oasis (MAFOUB) included a stratigraphic trench within the Ark (Trench A) and larger excavation areas in both the citadel (Trench C) and the shahrestan (Trenches B and D). The three specimens analysed in the present study (LL155, LL158, and LL162) all originate from Trench A within the Ark. Samples LL155 and LL158 were

recovered from Islamic occupation layers dated to the 10th–12th centuries CE. Sample LL162 derives from a mixed archaeological context containing ceramic material dated between the 4th and 9th centuries CE. (Rante, 2019, 2024a)

Iskijkat is situated in the central part of the Bukhara Oasis (Uzbekistan) on the route connecting Samarkand to Bukhara. The settlement follows the characteristic tripartite layout of many Central Asian urban centres, comprising a fortified citadel, an open shahrestan, and an extensive suburban area. Archaeological investigations by the Franco-Uzbek Archaeological Mission in the Bukhara Oasis (MAFOUB) included two deep stratigraphic trenches, one excavated within the citadel (Trench A) and the other in the shahrestan (Trench B). The earliest evidence of occupation dates to the 3rd–2nd centuries BCE. Subsequent occupation phases are documented during the 2nd–1st centuries BCE and again in the 2nd–3rd centuries CE. From Late Antiquity onwards, the settlement experienced a long period of continuity, with both the citadel and the surrounding urban areas remaining occupied between the 4th–5th and 7th centuries CE. During the 7th–8th centuries CE, occupation expanded beyond the core urban areas, suggesting renewed demographic growth. In the Early Islamic period (9th–10th centuries CE), settlement activity became increasingly concentrated within the citadel and shahrestan, while the suburban zones appear to have been primarily devoted to commercial and craft activities. Occupation contracted substantially after this period, and evidence for the 12th–16th centuries CE is currently restricted to the citadel, indicating a marked reduction in the extent of the settlement, particularly after the 13th century. The two specimens analysed in the present study originate from Iskijkat. Sample LL155 derives from a context dated between the 1st century BCE and the 2nd century CE, while sample LL156 was recovered from deposits attributed to a broader phase spanning the 2nd/3rd to the 6th centuries CE (Bruno, 2024; Delphine et al., 2024; Rante, 2024b).

Kakishtuvan is located on the north-western edge of the Bukhara Oasis (Uzbekistan), along the corridor connecting Bukhara to Khorezm. Like several major urban centres of the oasis, the settlement displays a tripartite organisation composed of a fortified citadel, a shahrestan (lower city), and an extensive suburban area. Archaeological investigations have shown that the earliest occupation was established within the citadel during the 1st century CE, as documented by the

stratigraphic sequence excavated in Trench A by the Franco-Uzbek Archaeological Mission in the Bukhara Oasis (MAFOUB). Available archaeological evidence indicates that the shahrestan developed later, probably during the 3rd–4th centuries CE. Settlement activity intensified during the 5th century CE, as reflected by an increase in both occupation and construction phases. The stratigraphic sequence suggests a gradual decline of the citadel during the 6th–7th centuries CE, followed by progressive abandonment in the decades after the Islamic conquest. Nevertheless, the site remained occupied during the 9th–12th centuries CE, with more limited evidence of activity continuing into the Timurid period. The specimen analysed in the present study (LL161) derives from a context dated between the 4th and 6th centuries CE (Bruno, 2024; Rante, 2024a, 2019).

Kafir-kala is located approximately 12 km southeast of Afrasiab (ancient Samarkand, Uzbekistan), along the Dargom canal. Covering around 20 ha, the site occupies a naturally defended position surrounded by watercourses and rises prominently above the surrounding plain. The settlement consists of a fortified citadel, a shahristan protected by moats and defensive earthworks, and an associated suburban area. Archaeological investigations conducted by the Uzbek-Japanese expedition initially focused on the citadel (Trench 1) before expanding to several areas of the shahristan. Excavations have revealed substantial architectural remains, including a large hall in the Sharestan Area (Trench 5). The earliest securely dated occupation of the site dates to the 4th century CE. Kafir-kala experienced significant development between the 5th and early 8th centuries CE before undergoing a major destruction episode during the early Islamic conquest. Archaeological evidence indicates subsequent reoccupation which ended abruptly with another destructive fire around the mid-8th century, while occupation continued intermittently through the Medieval period. Three specimens analysed in the present study originate from Kafir-kala. Samples LL159 and LL160 were recovered from 8th–9th century CE occupation levels within the hall located in the shahristan. Sample LL163 derives from Room 12 of the citadel and is likewise dated to the 8th–9th centuries CE (Begmatov, 2020; Begmatov et al., 2024; “(PDF) TIMBER AND FLORA FROM KAFIR-KALA IN SAMARKAND,” 2026).